

Oklahoma State - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	A credible above-average Power 4 / top-40 model team after a 1-11 collapse, but one of the least stable evaluations in the field because the staff and most of the two-deep are new.
Preseason consensus	AP Unranked ; 8 points in others receiving votes · SP+ No. 39
Returning production	58% (No. 44) overall · Off. 62% (No. 35) · Def. 53% (No. 65)
Primer power rating	+7.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.7 wins · likely 7-5
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Better - Materially better. The 2025 team was bottom-tier by both traditional and advanced measures; the 2026 model, staff reset and transfer talent support a large rebound, though almost none of that improvement is bankable through shared continuity.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Eric Morris installs an up-tempo Air Raid around QB Drew Mestemaker and a transfer-heavy offense; the new defense uses a multiple 4-2-5. The profile is upside versus cohesion.

Bottom line: Bowl contention is plausible, but extraordinary roster/staff turnover makes the +7.0 rating unusually unstable.

Beats expectations if: QB Drew Mestemaker translates quickly, the transfer OL stabilizes, and the rebuilt defense finds enough cohesion to win near-peer Big 12 games.

Disappoints if: OL health slows the Air Raid and transfer-heavy defensive units cannot escape 2025's explosive-play/havoc problems.

Five things to remember

- 2025 baseline:** The 2025 baseline was poor: 1-11, No. 134 scoring offense, No. 124 adjusted offense and No. 106 adjusted defense.
- ♦ **Roster overhaul:** The 58% returning-production figure masks massive churn: more than 80 newcomers, including 62 incoming transfers, were announced.
- Coaching structure:** HC Eric Morris calls the up-tempo Air Raid; OC Sean Brophy coaches quarterbacks.
- ★ **QB Drew Mestemaker:** QB Drew Mestemaker, RB Caleb Hawkins and WR Wyatt Young all carry major preseason recognition.
- ? **Availability / open roles:** OT Braydon Nelson's health, DT Iman Oates' eligibility and open TE/center/return roles are the key structural questions.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	1-11 (0-9 Big 12)	● Very poor
Scoring	14.2 PPG	● Very poor
Total offense	292.4 YPG	● Very poor
Rush offense	118.3 YPG · 3.5 YPC	● Poor
Pass efficiency	5.71 YPA · 7 TD / 10 INT	● Very poor
Third downs	34.8%	● Poor
Scoring defense	33.3 PPG allowed	● Very poor
Total defense	418.3 YPG allowed	● Poor
Rush defense	165.9 YPG · 4.3 YPC	● Below average
Pass defense	252.4 YPG · 8.91 YPA · 28 TD allowed	● Very poor

The 2025 offense was bottom-tier (No. 134 scoring/pass efficiency, No. 130 total), and the defense was similarly poor (No. 126 scoring, No. 116 total).

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-7.13 · No. 124	● Very poor
Off. EPA/play	-0.207 · No. 130	● Very poor
Off. success rate	34.9% · No. 132	● Very poor
Off. explosive-play rate	9.1% · No. 131	● Very poor
Havoc allowed	18.6% · No. 124	● Very poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	-4.94 · No. 106	● Poor
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.114 · No. 113	● Poor
Def. success rate allowed	44.1% · No. 100	● Below average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	14.2% · No. 121	● Very poor
Havoc created	14.3% · No. 93	● Below average

Advanced-stat read: There was no hidden foundation: offense was bottom-15 across key efficiency measures and defense outside the top 100 in adjusted rating/EPA. The 2026 case is a new-people/new-system projection, not simple regression to the mean.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play-caller	◆ Eric Morris - new external hire from North Texas; offensive play-caller	● ↑ The full reset is risky, but Morris brings a defined offensive identity and keeps the play-calling role that made the staff transition coherent rather than split between new voices.
OC / QBs	◆ Sean Brophy - new external hire from North Texas; Morris calls plays	● ↑ Brophy arrives with Morris and inherits several North Texas transfers, reducing terminology/relationship friction even though the roster is new to Oklahoma State.
DC	◆ Skyler Cassity - new external hire from North Texas	● ↑ The multiple 4-2-5/deep-rotation plan is a plausible answer to a defense that ranked No.106 adjusted in 2025, but so many projected contributors are transfers that implementation certainty remains low.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Drew Mestemaker	North Texas	● ↑ Projected QB1 and Big 12 preseason newcomer of the year.
◆ RB Caleb Hawkins	North Texas	● ↑ Expected lead back with Walter Camp second-team/Doak/Maxwell recognition.
◆ WR Wyatt Young	North Texas	● ↑ Likely starter with first-team Big 12/Biletnikoff recognition.
◆ OT Braydon Nelson	North Texas	● ↔ Potential starting LT; knee recovery keeps Week 1 status uncertain.

Out	To	Loss
QB Hauss Hejny	Colorado State	● ↔ 2025 opening starter departs; QB Drew Mestemaker is now QB1.
WR/QB Sam Jackson V	New York Jets rookie-minicamp tryout	● ↔ Hybrid contributor exits after a Jets rookie-minicamp tryout; no NFL roster membership is established.
OL Bob Schick	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Veteran starting experience leaves a transfer-heavy OL.

Offense net: ● ↑ Better projected QB/RB/WR quality, but transfer-built improvement and OL health keep stability low.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Ethan Wesloski	North Texas	● ↑ Projected starter with Butkus recognition.
◆ DE James Williams	Florida State	● ↑ Expected starting edge in the rebuilt front.
◆ DT Saadiq Clements	North Texas	● ↔ First-unit DT while DT Iman Oates' eligibility remains unsettled.
◆ CB Mo Horn	Texas Tech	● ↔ Likely starting corner opposite CB LaDainian Fields.

Out	To	Loss
S Dylan Smith	Memphis	● ↓ Multiple-start safety departure adds to the rebuild.
LB Brandon Rawls	Undrafted; Oklahoma State Pro Day; no NFL signing	● ↓ Leading 2025 tackler departs after Oklahoma State Pro Day; no NFL team is established.
LB Bryan McCoy Jr.	Undrafted; Oklahoma State Pro Day; no NFL signing	● ↓ Another leading 2025 tackler departs.

Defense net: ● ↑ A top-50 projection is better than 2025, but continuity is weak and DT Iman Oates' eligibility can change the front.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Up-tempo Air Raid under Eric Morris, with rapid practice sequencing and a deliberate multi-back workload rather than overloading RB Caleb Hawkins.	QB Drew Mestemaker/RB Caleb Hawkins/WR Wyatt Young carry strong preseason recognition, and multiple skill/OL transfers already have projected first-unit roles.	The QB and most of the line are new to Oklahoma State; Nelson's knee and the center/TE competitions can still alter the early structure.
Defense	Cassity's 4-2-5 uses both three- and four-man fronts, heavy positional multiplicity and a deep DL rotation - his "controlled chaos" concept.	EDGE Kobe Wesloski, DL Jaleel Johnson and CB LaDainian Fields provide identifiable anchors while the transfer class adds athleticism.	Communication and front consistency are largely unproven, and DT Iman Oates' eligibility can still change the rotation.
Special teams	New primary specialists with unresolved return assignments.	SP+ gives the unit a strong No.26 preseason signal.	The projected K/P roles are new and the return jobs remain unsettled.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B	● ↑	Medium	QB Drew Mestemaker is the supported starter and Big 12 preseason newcomer of the year, but still leads a near-total rebuild.
RB	● A–	● ↑	Medium-high	RB Caleb Hawkins is the projected lead back with Walter Camp second-team/Doak/Maxwell recognition.
WR	● B+	● ↑	Medium	WR Wyatt Young leads a talented but almost entirely new group with first-team Big 12/Biletnikoff recognition.
TE	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	TE Jace Hammond has the current lean over TE Josh Green, but the competition remains open.
OL	● B–	● ↑	Low	Transfer talent raises the floor, but OT Braydon Nelson's knee, center competition and multiple new starters create major risk.
DL/Edge	● B–	● ↑	Low	DL Jaleel Johnson and transfer depth lead a highly rebuilt front whose ceiling changes if DT Iman Oates is fully eligible.
LB	● B	● ↔	Medium-low	LB Derek Wesloski/LB Bryan Chisom project first after major 2025 tacklers LB Brandon Rawls/LB Bryan McCoy Jr. departed.
Secondary	● B–	● ↑	Medium-low	CB LaDainian Fields is the returning anchor for a largely new projected alignment.
Special teams	● B	● ↑	Medium-low	SP+ ranks the unit No. 26, but the primary specialists are new and return jobs remain open.
Coaching	● B+	● ↑	Medium	HC Eric Morris/OC Sean Brophy and the new defensive staff bring shared system familiarity but are all new to Oklahoma State.
Overall	● B	● ↑	Medium-low	SP+ No.39 supports above-average Power 4 quality and a massive rebound, but low shared continuity prevents a more confident top-30 grade.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Drew Mestemaker	QB	● High-upside transfer starter / rebuild fulcrum	Big 12 Preseason Newcomer of the Year · Maxwell	Projected QB1 and the player most capable of making the wholesale offensive reset function immediately.
Caleb Hawkins	RB	● Nationally recognized lead back	Walter Camp 2nd · Doak Walker · Maxwell · Walter Camp Player of the Year	Projected lead back with the strongest national preseason recognition on the roster; the offense can lean on him without making him a workhorse every snap.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Wyatt Young	WR	● High-end conference receiver	Big 12 1st team · Biletnikoff	Projected starter and force-to-Players-to-Know flag; primary proven-name target in a new receiver room.
Ethan Wesloski	LB	● Potential defensive centerpiece	Butkus	Projected starting linebacker and the clearest recognized defender in Cassity's new unit.
Jaleel Johnson	DE	● Returning edge anchor	-	One of the limited returning OSU players with prior starts and a projected first-unit edge role.
LaDainian Fields	CB	● Returning starting corner	-	Rare continuity piece in the secondary; projected starter after returning with prior OSU starts.
James Williams	DE	● Transfer starting edge / pressure upside	-	Projected starter from Florida State and a central piece of the deep-rotation front.
Christian Bodnar	NB	● Multi-role nickel	-	His CB/S background enables the flexible nickel/safety alignments that define Cassity's scheme.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Manageable for a +7.0 team but not soft: Oregon and Texas Tech are clear upper-tier tests, while a long middle/late run of similarly rated Big 12 teams makes execution consistency more important than one marquee upset.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 40
Hardest stretch	at Houston → Colorado → at Iowa State → at Kansas State → Texas Tech (Oct. 17-Nov. 14): five straight conference games, three on the road, ending with the No.34 and No.8 SP+ teams.
Swing games	at Houston, at Iowa State, at Kansas State, at Arizona State, Kansas
Advantage	The Oct. 3 bye falls before UCF and the core schedule includes several teams clustered around or below Oklahoma State's rating, creating multiple realistic win opportunities even without beating Oregon/Texas Tech.
Expected	6.7 wins · likely 7-5
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 9-3

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	A 1-11 baseline collides with SP+ No. 39; treat the opening month as a translation test. Offensive staff/QB continuity can drive a major jump, but contender-level pricing should wait until the rebuilt defense proves it can get off the field against Power 4 offenses.
Back them when	The OL is stable, QB Drew Mestemaker runs the tempo cleanly and the rebuilt defense avoids assignment busts.
Fade/pass when	The market prices ceiling before cohesion, OT Braydon Nelson/DT Iman Oates change the trenches, or explosive-play problems persist.
Key monitor	QB Drew Mestemaker efficiency, OT Braydon Nelson/final OL five, DT Iman Oates eligibility, TE/center winners, defensive communication, return assignments
Week 1 baseline	vs. Tulsa: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Oklahoma State –14.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Oklahoma State is a true rebuild rather than a normal bounce-back: the 1-11 baseline was poor, the roster turned over by more than 80 newcomers, and most projected units are transfer-built. There is real upside, though, with QB Drew Mestemaker, RB Caleb Hawkins and WR Wyatt Young carrying strong preseason signals into Eric Morris's up-tempo Air Raid.

SP+ No. 39 supports a massive improvement, not instant stability. OL health, front-seven cohesion and the eligibility of DT Iman Oates can swing several near-peer Big 12 games, so the most useful expectation is above-average Power 4 quality with a wide range rather than assuming the roster overhaul immediately produces contender-level consistency.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [camp / roles](#) · [scheme](#) · [departures](#) · [2025 context](#) · [team source](#) · [team source 2](#)

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